

BACK TO THE WALL Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray meets the press at his home, Matoshree, in Mumbai, Jan. 10

THACKERAY MUST MANAGE THE CONTRADICTIONS INHERENT IN TIES WITH HIS SECULAR ALLIES, WHILE ALLAYING THE CONCERNS OF THE MARATHI *MANOOS*

tal, they will not forgive Shinde for betraying Balasaheb's son," he says. Maharashtrians are not a majority in Mumbai but the largest minority—a demographic that comes with its own set of insecurities and spans the electorate in the Greater Mumbai region. An ex-BJP minister, too, concedes that a section of pro-Hindutva Maharashtrians feel uneasy at Shinde being handed a party that was considered inseparable from its First Family—the Thackerays. An independent legislator close to the BJP admits the saving grace for the Thackeray has been that the masses may not have accepted Shinde as the rightful inheritor. "The idea of Shinde, a rickshaw-wala turned chief minister, has failed to click," he admits.

The UBT faction is also hoping to craft a new social coalition that sees it become more than just a Hindutva party. Hence its 'Marathi-Muslim' social engineering project, through which it also hopes to attract the Muslim vote to defeat the 'larger evil' that is the BJP. As anecdotal evidence, they cite how Muslims voted for the party in the 2022 byelection to the Andheri (East) assembly seat. The community had also voted tactically for the Sena in the 2014 state assembly election and the 2017 Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) polls, when it had contested separately from the BJP.

Thackeray's men also believe their leader's soft image, previous attempts to broadbase the party and reach out to hitherto inimical groups like the Hindi speakers and Buddhist Dalits, and the MVA government's crackdown on the Bullibai app creators (which had launched a mock online auction of Muslim women) could influence minority votes. "Our victory," says the Sena (UBT) leader, "depends on the success of the Marathi-Muslim social